

Making the most of US extracurriculars

Making the most of your extracurricular activities

When applying to a university in the United States, it's important to know what admissions officers are looking for. Unlike the UK, US admissions officers are looking for more well-rounded students who take part in extra-curricular activities. In fact, what you do outside of the classroom can be just as important as what you do in it.

Why are extracurricular activities so important?

The United States is known for having what is called a liberal arts approach to education. Universities tend to focus on helping you develop a wide range of academic and professional skills. This is pretty different from other systems, like the United Kingdom, where offers are based on predicted A-level or IB grades. In the US, admission officers want to see how you will contribute to campus life. Getting involved with societies and hobbies beyond the classroom is a great way to show what this could look like.

In very competitive applicant pools, like the Ivy League, most of the other students will also have really high scores. Extracurricular achievements may be one of the most important ways you can stand out from the crowd. Try and pursue activities you genuinely care about, as it's likely you will have to write an admissions essay where you discuss them. This is a lot easier to do if you have a real interest in your chosen activities!

To help you find extracurricular activities that you are passionate about, and also demonstrate important skills, we'll go through five things that colleges want to see in your application.

1. Leadership

For admissions officers, showing leadership skills makes them more confident that you will go on to leave a positive mark on the university campus - and the world!

Leadership can be shown in a variety of ways. Did you find a club, advance from junior member to leader of a group, or convince a group of students to participate in a certain activity? If so, you have shown leadership skills, and you should mention these experiences in your applications.

2. Impact

It's one thing to have a hobby or skill, but it's quite another to be impactful. For example, many people can join a soccer team, but not everyone can score a lot of winning goals.

You can also connect your extracurricular activities to your ambitions. If you have an interest in macroeconomics, you might not have had your extracurricular research published, but you could show how your research led you to making different choices in your own life. A good strategy for writing well about activities is to consider what goal you had when you initially started doing an activity if you are still doing it for the same reason, and how you feel the activity has contributed to that goal.

3. Commitment

Colleges want to see that you can spend a serious amount of time on meaningful activities. If you describe your dancing class as life-changing but have only been four times, admissions officers will have a hard time believing you!

Try to focus on a few core activities, rather than doing twenty irrelevant things to look more impressive. The Common App will only allow you to enter ten extracurricular activities, and in supplemental essays, many colleges ask you to describe a single activity that had a profound impact on you.

4. Social Good

Top US universities tend to look for students who will use their education to make a positive impact on the world. It's great if one of your extracurricular activities is focused on improving the lives of other people. For example, if you're passionate about fighting homelessness, you might volunteer at a local soup kitchen or homeless shelter in order to put that passion into action.

Or maybe you really care about anti-racism and started a community group dedicated to educating people about how they can tackle racism together. You can choose just about any issue that inspires you - what really matters is your ability to find a practical way to do some good in society.

5. Summer breaks

In the United States, the summer before your college applications are due, are rarely a time to kick your feet up and relax! It's common to use the extra free time to start an impressive new project or get further involved in an activity you were already pursuing throughout the year.

If you play soccer during term time, you might use the summer to teach soccer camps in poorer neighborhoods. Holding a summer job is valuable too, not just for the college admissions process, but to boost your CV. It'll really help your application, and give you something meaningful to do during a time when you have less pressure from school.

The US application process is 'holistic' - admissions officers really do want to know what activities you've done. The Common App's 'Activities' section gives students the opportunity to list up to 10 activities they've done; here's advice on how to ace it.

More than just numbers

The US university system values so much more than just grades. US admissions officers pay more attention to your extracurricular activities than in maybe any other country.

Here's what Baltimore's Johns Hopkins University has to say about their approach:

“The admissions committee conducts a holistic review of every applicant based on his or her accomplishments, goals, and fit with our community. We're looking for students who will truly thrive as Johns Hopkins undergraduates. Each required item is requested for a reason and contributes to our evaluation.”

Along with a personal essay, supplemental essays, Letters of Recommendation from the student's counselor, and possibly multiple letters from the student's teachers, the Common App's 'Activities' section is an example of US universities wanting to get to know all about every prospective student.

The Common App's Activities section

The Common Application activities section asks for:

- the 'type' (such as community service, cultural, debate/speech, sports, etc)
- the 'position/leadership description and organization name' (50 characters)
- a description of the activity and your accomplishments (150 characters)
- the grades (year groups) of participation
- the timing of your participation (during school year, during school break, all year)
- hours spent per week
- weeks spent per year
- whether you intend to participate in a similar activity in college

You're limited to ten activities, and you have to rank them in order of importance.

The 150-character-long descriptions are the most important thing here. They should provide additional information that your personal essay and supplemental writing don't cover. They should give a sense of what you do that isn't contained in your grades and test scores.

Ideally, the activity descriptions tell the story of your personal interests and ambitions, and make you seem well-rounded.

What sort of activities should you include?

You can only include activities that you've done in high school (grades 9 through 12 for the US system, and years 10 through 13 for the UK system).

These activities could include:

- Extra academic endeavors
 - Research, honor clubs, tutoring...
- Community service
 - Through the local community or a school/global club
- Sport teams
 - Include whether you had a leadership position such as captain, or received an award
- Performing arts
 - Theater, musicals, acting classes, singing, band, dancing, and what role you had in the production
- Conferences and competitions
 - Model United Nations, international or national youth political conferences, math competitions, sports conferences....
- Jobs and internships
 - Include whether they were paid or voluntary
- Summer camps
 - Investing time during vacation shows extra dedication
 - Camps could include language immersion camps, specific subject camps (such as journalism, psychology, law, and medicine), intensive sports camps, and more.
- Any other activity that you believe is important in communicating who you are to the university

- If you have a passion for woodworking at home, this should be included even if you were just doing it on your own

What to include in each Activity's description

Before you start writing, ask yourself these questions:

- Why are you including this activity in your list?
- What does this activity tell the admissions officer about you?
- What did this activity mean to you?

Top tips

- Since the description is so limited in length, don't waste space repeating information from the description like the name of the organization or what role you held.
- Abbreviations (NHS instead of National Honor Society) can also save space.
- Find a balance between overconfidence and being too modest: don't downplay what you achieved, but don't make it sound more impressive than it really was, either.
- Use the active voice and verbs instead of the passive voice, eg "Harry ate six shrimps at dinner" (active), vs "At dinner, six shrimp were eaten by Harry" (passive)
- Use bullet points or listings instead of full sentences.
- Be as concise as possible - if you can use fewer words, do!

Examples of good and bad descriptions

Good example

Position/Leadership description and organization name: Editor, The Daily (school newspaper)

Please describe this activity, including what you accomplished and any recognition you received: Run weekly meetings, brainstorm ideas, assign and revise 10 articles/week, collaborate with printer to distribute 500 copies to students and faculty.

The description name is detailed, so you don't have to repeat "editor" or the newspaper's name in the description, saving words.

This description is concise (listing is efficient with words), contains good detail (using numbers is helpful), and uses active verbs.

Mediocre example

Position/Leadership description and organization name: Retreat Leader

Please describe this activity, including what you accomplished and any recognition you received: 9 seniors are chosen as leaders of the junior retreat. We meet weekly to critique each other's speeches and learn to mediate small group discussions.

Although the description is strong in the sense that the writer is demonstrating that they were part of a select few leaders, the description name could have provided more detail on what type of retreat the student was leading, and what leadership role they had. For example, if the student was a facilitator, the name could be "Junior Retreat Leader Facilitator." By adding details (junior and facilitator) to the name in the description, there would have been more space for the students to include details about what they actually did on the retreat, or the impact their work had on the participants.